At a Warsaw Pact meeting of Central Committee secretaries in the Polish capital in January 1987, the Soviet delegation was forced to listen to a chorus of disquiet. Fists were shaken as the old guard bemoaned the spill over from perestroika was causing ‘political discomfitures’. Opening proceedings, Czech leader Gustav Husák said piously that it was unwise to regard the Soviet reform process as irreversible. Bulgarian leader, Todor Hristov Zhivkov, kept in mind how Khrushchev’s reforms resulted in the Hungarian revolt. Having lapped-up Husák and Zhivkov’s performances, Honecker put on an energetic one-man show by asserting Soviet reforms might trigger a Yugoslav-style break with Marxist-Leninism. For good measure, he branded Mikhail Shatrov’s revisionist new play about Lenin a ‘betrayal’ of the October Revolution and argued against dissident Andrei Sakharov’s release from exile in Gorki. Faced with such opposition, the solution, according to Gorbachev, was to turn perestroika into a success and make the naysayers want to imitate it.

Beyond the artificial calm of the Warsaw Pact meeting, Gorbachev privately warned the Soviet Politburo if the outrages continued, he would stop supplies of gas and oil to the GDR or demand payment in hard currency. By this point, Gorbachev’s suspicions of the GDR’s impressive economic figures had prompted him to privately liken Honecker to Ostap Bender, a fictional conman and the protagonist in the novel The Twelve Chairs.8 He came to detest Honecker’s habit of praising himself in the presence of senior Soviet officials, while continually extolling the GDR’s stability and economic prosperity.

An impatient man, Gorbachev found it hard to tolerate such smugness and at one point supposedly even considered overthrowing Honecker. As the story goes, he even sounded out Hans Modrow, the moderate SED leader in Dresden, as a possible successor. At the same time, it was also alleged that diplomats from the Russian Embassy in East Berlin had been spreading the word that Modrow was considered by Gorbachev as Honecker’s preferred successor. (Rumours abounded but were never proven that Gorbachev and Modrow had known each other at university in Moscow during the 1950s.) Years later, the Berlin Morgenpost claimed Valentin Falin, the former Soviet ambassador to Bonn, confirmed the reports.9 Further insight was provided by the former Russian ambassador to the GDR, Vyacheslav